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1947–1971: Independence and Non-Alignment

The Cold War: US and Soviet Bipolarity

India became independent two years after the end of World War II and under very specific geopolitical circumstances. The World War had caused considerable devastation in Europe and East Asia, while the decolonization movement had gained momentum in Africa and Asia, with India at the vanguard. But even by 1947, when an indebted and war-weary Britain hastily partitioned and left India, it was clear a Cold War was already underway between one bloc led by the United States and another led by the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (USSR). Both the US and the Soviet Union had booming war economies and they had partitioned Europe and Korea. This was now a bipolar world.

The USSR was founded after the Russian Revolution of 1917. Led by Vladimir Lenin, the revolution was inspired by the ideas of Karl Marx, a nineteenth-century German intellectual who lived much of his later life in Britain. Marx argued that history was a class struggle that would conclude with the rise of the working classes and society's eventual organization into ideal self-governing communes. The Communist Revolution in Russia inspired revolutionaries in China, Europe, Southeast Asia, Africa, India, the United States, and Latin America. Communist International (or Comintern) held its first congress in 1919 and promised to create an 'international Soviet republic as a transition stage to the complete abolition of the State'. [1]

Meanwhile, the United States under President Franklin D. Roosevelt was emerging from the Great Depression and decades of relative isolationism. In January 1941, almost a year before the United States entered the World War II, Roosevelt laid out an ambitious vision of 'a world founded upon